



ers falling fast, they are virtually replacing all other secondary storage devices at the desktop level as the primary storage and backup solution. Today a 52X CD-Writer costs only around Rs 5,000. In contrast, even a year ago a 32X used to cost at least Rs 8,000. Similarly, CD-R media sold for Rs 25 to 35 a year ago, but today they cost around Rs 13 for a 700 MB disk. These drives can also read CD-RW media, which can be used up to 50 times and cost around Rs 75 each. This further reduces running costs in a big way.

All these advantages have seen CD-Writers being accepted in a big way, whether it's for data backup, moving work from office to home, or creating back-ups for all your favourite MP3s and movies. So, CD-Writers could be your best choice at the moment. The same cannot be said for external CD-Writers, since today a 48X external CD-Writer can cost as much as Rs 9,000.

These should be considered only if you really need them.

Though DVD-Writers have been touted by vendors for a year or so, they have been priced far out of reach of the average home user. Nearly all DVD-Writers are priced between Rs 27,000 and Rs 35,000, which can hardly be called affordable. Also, the price of DVD-R media can vary from Rs 90 for unbranded ones to Rs 400 for good-quality branded options. Further, there's a lot of confusion over DVD-R media formats currently available in the market.

Though this technology is far superior to CD-Writers in terms of amount of data storage and reliability, the high cost makes them affordable only to a handful of people. But it's only a matter of time for prices to fall and for DVD-Writers to become as affordable as CD-Writers, so do have the patience to wait!

USB Pen drives from popular brands like Iomega, Creative and IBM have suddenly caught the attention of buyers. These drives no longer come as just a storage device—many have integrated a full-function MP3 player into these drives. The prices for these drives vary a lot depending on the capacity of the drive and any extra frills it has. A standard 128 MB drive should cost around Rs 3,500, and the same capacity drive with an integrated MP3 players should set you back by Rs 7,500 or so. These drives can be considered as an ideal replacement for floppy drives.

Also Remember...

■ Types of media that can be used are CD-R and CD-RW. The advantage of the more expensive CD-RW media is that it is reusable.

■ If you have an older system, you may not be able to write at speeds faster than 8x, because your system is incapable of feeding the writer with data at the required rate. This is usually due to slower hard drives, low processing power and limited RAM.



Buying Tips

DVD-ROMs

- Since 16X is the fastest speed available it is advisable to go in for that.
- Please take a look at the various formats the drive can play. Most DVD players can't play all the formats. If you have a DVD-RW it may be possible it can't read that disc. In that case, a new DVD-ROM will be a bad investment.
- Also ask for the warranty period and the parts covered in the warranty.
- Make sure you buy a DVD-ROM drive which has at least a buffer memory of 512 KB.
- A slot DVD Rom will last longer than the tray one. Hence it is advisable to invest in a Slot DVD-ROM.
- Ensure that a good DVD playback software such as WinDVD is provided along with the drive.
- A DVD-ROM drive should be able to read dual-sided DVD media.

CD-Writers

- Make sure the drive has a high spin speed and low access times. Access time is more important if you need to read non-sequential data such as games.
- It should support oversizing/overburning.
- It should support TAO, DAO, Multi-Session and Incremental Packet Writing.
- It should support RAW writing.
- It should include CD-burning software.

General Checklist

- The drive's firmware should be upgradable for future support.
- Drivers for all major operating systems should be included.
- The audio and IDE cables should be included in the package.
- It should have at least a one-year warranty.